

Here, in rural isolation and under Beckford's sponsorship, Clementi spent the next seven years practicing harpsichord and studying music. His Six Sonatas for the Harpsichord or Pianoforte, Op. 1, date from this period.

London and abroad

In 1774, aged 22 and now free of his seven-year indenture with Beckford, Clementi moved to London, where he worked initially as a “keyboard conductor” at the King's Theatre. In 1779, he published his Three Sonatas, Op. 2, which are widely considered to have been a major breakthrough in keyboard-writing—his reputation as a dazzling composer-performer grew. Success inspired him to embark on a promotional tour of France, Germany, and Austria—this was the first of many visits to Europe. In Vienna, he was honored in 1781 with an invitation from Emperor Joseph II to play at the imperial court, where he met Mozart (see [box](#)).

After 1781, on his return to his home base in London, Clementi's focus turned from the harpsichord to a newly invented instrument, the piano. In 1782, Clementi's Three Piano Sonatas, Op. 40, boosted his career as a composer-performer. By his early thirties he was famous in Europe, reaching his professional peak between 1785 and 1790, the year in which his innovative Sonata in F-sharp minor, Op. 25, No. 5, appeared—introducing, in parts, a slower, more introspective mood into the music of the period.

With a shrewd eye to a potentially lucrative market, in 1798 Clementi invested in a music publishing and piano manufacturing company, known as Clementi & Co. from 1800, which proved